

How India and China Stack Up

Comparative strengths of the two countries along the LAC in Arunachal Pradesh



ROAD CONNECTIVITY China has an extensive road network across the Tibetan plateau, supporting movement of troop and materiel. It's supplemented by railways, airports, military hubs

FRONTIER PRESENCE Chinese border settlements and their supporting infrastructure can help sustain a permanent presence in remote areas

MILITARY DEPTH Forward border defence units deployed along LAC are backed by larger Combined Arms Brigades that integrate infantry with armour, artillery, air defence, reconnaissance and electronic warfare

ESTABLISHED PRESENCE The Indian military is familiar with the local terrain and has experience in operating in high-altitude conditions

NEW INFRASTRUCTURE BRO's Vartak, Arunank, Udayak and Brahmank projects expand road and bridge connectivity. The Sela Tunnel provides all-weather access to Tawang

DEFENSIVE ADVANTAGE Steep ridgelines, narrow valley approaches favour defenders

LOCAL COMMUNITIES Border residents help gather intelligence and help the military by supplying rations

strategy to the realities of modern warfare, where drones, electronic warfare and real-time intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance systems are as critical as troop deployments and physical infrastructure," says Lt Gen. Anil Ahuja (retd), who commanded a mountain division in Arunachal. He feels the army and the ITBP need a more integrated command, enabling them to share intelligence and respond swiftly to emerging threats.

WHY ARUNACHAL MATTERS

Though till the 1980s China laid claim to only Tawang, the broader claim to the entire state of Arunachal Pradesh—calling it South Tibet or Zangnan—was amplified only after that and more concertedly since the 2000s. Of the 3,488 km-long LAC, the longest stretch—over 1,080 km—lies along Arunachal Pradesh which, together with Sikkim, forms the eastern sector of the border with China.

Among the three army corps responsible for this sector, 33 Corps in Sikkim is assessed as the strongest, while IV Corps (Gajraj Corps) covering the Tezpur–Tawang sector is also considered well-equipped. The III Corps, responsible for 80 per cent of Arunachal, is the weakest in terms of mobility.

Lt Gen. Narasimhan explains that frontier areas such as Longju, Asaphila and Taksing have posed problems because of poor road connectivity. "Successive corps commanders, including myself, have tried to build roads up to the border, but the treacherous conditions make it extremely difficult. Until we achieve better connectivity, the only way to deal with such scenarios is increased surveillance using the latest technology."

A top military official points out that India is overly dependent on its air assets for logistics and deployment in many remote areas. In some sectors, Indian positions remain up to 80 km short of the LAC, leaving large stretches unmanned, and monitored only through long-range patrols. "Unlike Ladakh, the area was never prioritised by the Centre; the northern sector received preference for defence preparedness," he says.



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— LT GEN. RAJEEV CHAUDHARY (RETD)
Former Director General, Border Roads Organisation

INFRASTRUCTURE PUSH

Lt Gen. Rajeev Chaudhary (retd.), former Director General of the Border Roads Organisation (BRO), says China had benefitted from the relatively level terrain of the Tibetan plateau, while India's roads had to be built along steep mountain slopes and through fragile terrain. "China has been way ahead of us in border infrastructure purely because it is sitting on a plateau, while we are on the slope, so it has the geographical advantage," he says. China continues to strengthen its highway network, he says, making India's own construction drive an operational necessity. However, surveying remote areas, building roads through dense forests and stabilising mountain slopes can take years.